might be ignored, but the public aspect became important, and indeed a number of members who were present in your house were disturbed by this wider aspect of the problem. The lobbies were full of talk.

A day or two later, a meeting of the party took place where reference was made by several members to whispering campaigns. No names were mentioned but it was clear what was hinted at. I heard also that Government officials were themselves taking part in this whispering business and had encouraged the writing of editorials in newspapers criticizing me or what I had said.

This was an extraordinary state of affairs and I felt that I could hardly continue as Prime Minister if this kind of thing was taking place. Hence the feeling I showed in my speech to the party.

I have narrated some of these past events just to give the background of my own thought. We are facing today a crisis of the deepest magnitude and vital decisions have to be taken from time to time. Those decisions may be right or wrong, but they must be clear. If there is no clear objective or approach guiding them, they will tend to be confusing and contradictory. Hence it has become necessary that we should be perfectly clear about our official aims and policies. Naturally, existing circumstances and the succession of events force our hands.

But even so, we cannot ignore any basic policy that we may pursue.

The whole Bengal problem and the Indo-Pakistan issue have many facets – political, economic, communal, national and international. Of these, the communal aspect has great importance. Indeed the whole problem is in the nature of a communal problem. We have long stood for discouraging and putting an end to communalism. That has been the Congress policy and it has been repeated and affirmed by Parliament. We talk of a secular state. That of course simply means any normal state today, leaving out the abnormality of Pakistan’s Islamic state. We adopted our policy regardless of what the Muslim League or Pakistan might say or do, because we thought that was the only policy, both from the idealistic and the practical and opportunist points of view. Any other policy could only lead to disruption and disaster. Certain organizations, notably the Hindu Mahasabha, adopted